
Arsenal crisis continues as Arteta failings exposed again

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Arsenal crisis continues as Arteta failings exposed again

A run of three defeats in their first 49 games of the season put Arsenal on the precipice of unprecedented glory; as many losses in their last four mean they are on course to make history of a slightly different and entirely more ruinous kind.

Mikel Arteta implored Arsenal's fans to "have an early breakfast, bring your lunch, bring your dinner" for "a big day" at the Emirates. But by full-time they felt it necessary to turn to the boos as his players displayed precisely none of the requisite appetite or hunger against a positively ravenous Bournemouth.

Andoni Iraola does appear to have something of a hex over his Basque brethren. Bournemouth have won three of their last four meetings with Arsenal, including a 2-1 win to complete a league double over them last season, with [the Gunners having to come from behind for a momentous victory in January](#).

That win gave them a six-point lead atop the Premier League, clear of second-placed Aston Villa with a seven-point gap to a struggling Manchester City side with a game in hand.

Three months later, the difference is nine points but seems far smaller. Perhaps it is the two games in hand Manchester City hold now, or their clash at the Etihad next week which many have automatically assigned as a home win already due to the stunning swing in momentum.

But one of the more remarkable collapses of a team in Premier League history does instinctively feel very much on.

Those three defeats in their last four games have all come in different competitions, downgrading an unrealistic Quadruple to an unlikely Double with a significantly loosened grip on the Premier League trophy.

The domestic pressure is being felt most. [Their Carabao Cup final surrender](#) was followed by an insipid FA Cup exit to Southampton, while the sight of goalkeepers coming up for corners at the Emirates in stoppage time in their last two Premier League games exudes neither composure nor calm as the nerves bite.

[Max Dowman helped rescue them against Everton](#) before the international break, but the 16-year-old was part of a side swallowed whole by the occasion and opponent here.

He was part of the earliest Arteta triple substitution in Premier League history, a Hail Mary thrown in the 54th minute which achieved little more than simply changing the identity of the players unable to come up with an answer to an aggressive Bournemouth press.

There are two clear disconnects which define Arsenal right now: one between what the players are trying to do and what the fans want to see; and another between what Arteta is saying and how his squad is responding.

They wanted to play patiently against Bournemouth in the hope of forcing a less open, chaotic match, while the supporters bristled every time the ball was shifted back to the thoroughly unconvincing David Raya.

And Arteta continues to discuss a “beautiful” period of the season Arsenal need to savour and approach with relish, even while his players seem to be wilting in the spotlight.

Both Bournemouth goals had been coming, with Ryan Christie slicing Arsenal open for Eli Junior Kroupi’s opener and a sweeping team move culminating in Alex Scott running straight through the middle of the defence to score.

Viktor Gyokeres converted a first-half penalty in response but his final quarter of an hour was crushing: a frustrated booking and three half-chances snatched at each time.

The numbers did not even nearly add up but Gyokeres was at least standing up to be counted, which cannot be said for far too many of his team-mates at a crucial stage of the season. They were especially dreadful in open play, summed up by Gabriel’s late centre-forward cameo.

Even Arteta is failing to offer the direction Arsenal need. His perennial focus on the mentality and character of his players threatens to overlook the tactical shortcomings Manchester City, Southampton and Bournemouth in particular have exposed recently.

That has halved Arsenal’s potential trophy haul in a disastrous run, with the Bottlepocalypse still a live possibility.

READ NEXT: [Ranking the 25 Arsenal bottlejobs from Max Dowman to Mikel Arteta](#)

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